Wandering on the Shore

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COL-400401

This should have been a quiet night.

A moment of respite for those that tirelessly seek the truth.

—But not tonight.

Geometry Beach

The lamps flicker brightly, reflecting faintly off glossy pages.

210: I never would have expected our ever diligent corrector to be so taken with outside literature.

210: These weren't on the purchase list, were they?

Several colorful magazines are spread open in front of Sophia, 37 is hunched-over beside her, examining them as if they were rare and precious shells.

Sophia: ...I met several newsboys on the pier on my way back, and they clamored around trying to give me these.

Sophia: I was just preparing my report for 6, but it seems 37 has taken a special interest in them.

Thirty-seven: Of course, Sophia! Look the dimensions of these magazines form rectangles with a length equal to their width times the square root of 2!—an irrational number!

Thirty-seven: The way they so boldly turn their backs on integer ratios can only mean one thing—there is a profound meaning hidden within them! Naturally, we're going to have to read these magazines immediately to solve what mysteries they hold!

210: Let me solve this mystery for you, our Shining Star of Hermes. The hidden meaning is that they used A4 paper.

Thirty-seven: A4? What could any of this have to do with "A" or "4"... Unless A were a variable with a factor of 4... I must know more.

210: I'm afraid these contain neither deep mysteries nor hidden knowledge. They're just travel magazines.

210 reveals the name of the magazine in his hand.

Thirty-seven: "Wandering on the Shore"... published by UTTU Magazine?

Thirty-seven: Oh, wait take a look at the beach on the cover!

The beach is immediately recognizable as the very same on which they're standing.

Sophia: Strange... I wouldn't have expected the Lyceum to grant an interview to a magazine like this.

210: Oh... There's nothing strange about it, really.

210: This magazine must have been published after the first Emanation hit. Back then the island engaged in numerous exchanges with the outside to better understand its impact on the world.

210 flips through the pages briskly, until a confident smirk creeps onto his face.

210: See, I was exactly right - as always. These photos are of 77 and 42.

Sophia: Hmm? But the world beyond the islands has been ravaged by the Emanation many times now. They couldn't possibly have preserved records from back then... Unless-

Thirty-seven: Unless these magazines are from a land like our own, safe from the Emanation's reach.

Thirty-seven: UTTU Magazine... Convert UTTU into numbers, and you get 20, 19, 19, 20. What could it all mean?

37 is lost in deep contemplation, it almost seems as if there are numbers dancing over her head.

Sophia: Let's ask 6 if he knows anything about this UTTU Magazine.

Sophia: Strange, I thought I saw him on the beach with us earlier... but where is he now?

210 closes his magazine and looks down the beach with new interest.

As Sophia starts to look around. Her sharp-eyed companion immediately pounces upon a figure hidden behind a rock.

Thirty-seven: I found you, 6! But what were you doing back there! Why didn't you say hello?

Six: ...

Six: I had no intention of interrupting your frivolities... Besides, you didn't say anything either.

The leader puts some distance between himself and the others, brushing the sand off from his coat.

Six: I assure you, no offense was intended. You are more than free to read these magazines as you like...

Six: With that, I shall take my leave.

Try as he might to extract himself from this confrontation, 37 simply will not give him the space.

Thirty-seven: Wah! You want to hurry off so soon? You must know exactly where these magazine things are from.

Thirty-seven: A pivotal mystery is at hand, with mathematical ramifications that could shake the very foundations of the known world!

Six: There is no mystery at hand, 37- The previous leader simply had dealings with this publication and granted them an interview.

Six: Only it wasn't called UTTU back then... But never mind, forget I mentioned anything.

The leader abruptly halts himself as if to avoid any further probing.

Fortunately for him, the others seem not to catch his mumbling.

210: Oh, well, looks like they finally remembered to send us a copy.

210: In this time of pervasive regression, there's still a magazine out there steadily advancing forward, I'll take it as a good sign.

Sophia: Whatever the case, it has certainly piqued my interest to give it a read.

Thirty-seven: Who cares what they wrote in these things, none of that's important right now! The √2:1 formatting ratio is the key here! This is what we should be focusing our mental efforts on!

37 picks up three magazines from the ground, then hands them to 210, Sophia, and the still eager-to-depart 6.

Six: ...

6 sighs almost imperceptibly and places his fingers on the magazine's pages.

The Inheritors

COL-400402

Sophia: The magazine's descriptions of our island are quite evocative.

Sophia: Is this really how the island looks in the eyes of outsiders? I never would've thought...

Sophia: "The western cliffs of the island, without doubt, present the most beautiful views, from there one can take in its breath-taking vista over the sea..." I pass by there often, but I hardly think anything of it...

Thirty-seven: Clearly, this outsider doesn't know the first thing about this place!

Thirty-seven: Beautiful views? Pah! There's no point in going to the western cliff at all. It doesn't fall on any of the connecting lines of the structures here... It's just a- a redundant floating decimal!

Thirty-seven: If there was any spot worth visiting on the island, it would be Epsilon Cavern, deep underground.

Thirty-seven: The cavern lies at the perpendicular vertex of an equilateral triangle that fully encompasses the island, making it the most central and, thus, most mathematically perfect attraction on the island!

Sophia: I've never even seen you so much as step foot near that cave.

Thirty-seven: Of course, it's super dark down there!

Thirty-seven: But the numbers don't lie, it is the most perfect feature on the island, and to omit this self-evident truth! Humph! It ought to be reflected in any worthwhile magazine.

210: Or perhaps we can spare our would-be tourists the trauma of venturing into a pitch-black cave? I'm afraid you won't find many tourists who enjoy counting while rushing back and forth between the office and the beach either.

Thirty-seven: Be that as it may, they have no reason to bore themselves on that cliff. The arrangement of the stones there has no value at all.

Sophia: But it is the best place to gaze upon the sea.

Thirty-seven: The sea? But it's everywhere! It's no more interesting than a nonprime integer with an exponent of one!

Sophia: Perhaps it's in seeing the same things with new eyes that we find the true joy of travel, 37.

Confrontation

COL-400403

210: Sophia, you're the only one among us with any first-hand travel experience, do you have any travel advice?

Sophia: Do you mean when I came to the island with Hugh?

Sophia: Oh, I was too young at that time to remember anything about the trip.

210: That's a shame, I guess I was hoping we could learn something more about the outside world from you.

210: You know after I sent out those manuscripts, many admirers from the outside world wrote to me, inviting me to speak publicly about my experiences...

Thirty-seven: Answering 210's questions is always a mistake, Sophia. He never lets an opportunity to talk about himself slip by.

Thirty-seven: But... I'm curious too, if you were to leave the island, where would you go?

Sophia: If possible, I suppose I would like to go home and see how things are there.

Sophia: Although my childhood there was not exactly pleasant, that wasn't always the case...

Thirty-seven: Aha! The geometric location of the area indicates that it is, in fact, an excellent travel destination. Bravo! That would indeed be the right choice, Sophia.

Thirty-seven: What about you, 6? Where do you think you'd go?

Six: My thoughts are hardly of any importance.

Thirty-seven: Oh, so you'd follow in the footsteps of 77 and choose your destination by searching for the truth?

Six: I'm saying... I have no desire to travel at all.

Birth of Mathematics

COL-400404

210: How utterly lamentable.

As he flips through the pages, 210 heaves a long sigh.

210: Seeing the island from the eyes of an outsider is a novel experience.

210: But I have discovered a fatal flaw in this magazine.

No one responds. Sophia is focusing all her attention on her reading, while 37 seems to still be lost in enigmatic mystery of the magazines; irrational ratios.

However, 210 has never been one to let silence of even this extreme degree deter him. He continues speaking as if a lecturer to an empty classroom.

210: This magazine certainly offers a comprehensive description of the geography of the island and even a rudimentary grasp of the teachings of the Lyceum, but it completely neglects the most important aspect of life here, like a novice skipping over the most crucial step in a logical argument.

Thirty-seven: Just skip to what you are getting at? If you keep droning on like this you'll put us all to sleep, 210.

210: You truly are our Shining Star of Hermes. You have already answered the question I wished to pose.

210: **210.**

210: Exactly right, the most woeful aspect of this publication is that it failed to provide even a mention of myself.

210: The magazine mentions 77, our previous "6," but is missing the vital coverage of me and my illustrious wisdom.

210: This is glaring but surely accidental oversight knocks this magazine down several rungs in my estimation.

Thirty-seven: I'd say they did it on purpose.

Thirty-seven: Through this method, they will have successfully prevented their publication from being condemned to the bottom of a waste paper basket.

Thirty-seven: Indicating that they possess at the very least the common sense to recognize that their readers would be repelled by such long-winded absurdity.

210: Oh? Is that so? If that's the case, then they must feel the same about you, "Shining Star of Hermes," as you do not appear in their little magazine either.

Thirty-seven: Not at all. It's simply evidence that they cannot comprehend the depths of mathematical truth that I've illuminated.

Thirty-seven: They were only brief visitors from beyond the island's borders; therefore, clearly their time here was insufficient to develop an understanding of my research and its significance.

Sophia at the edge of her patience at last, reluctantly closes her magazine, intent on resolving their dispute.

Sophia: For all your boasting, you both seem to have evaded the obvious truth at the end of your noses. Neither of you were old enough to be mentioned when this article was published.